

Handout: Introduction to Dispositions and Their Analysis

I. The Problem: What Are Dispositions?

Philosophers have long been interested in a class of properties that seem to involve **tendencies, powers, or potentials**.

- A glass is **fragile**
- Sugar is **soluble**
- A person is **irascible**

These are not just descriptions of how things *are*, but of how they are **liable to behave under certain conditions**.

The Central Question

What does it mean to say that something has a disposition?

More precisely:

- What *makes it true* that something is fragile, soluble, or elastic?
 - Can we analyze dispositions in simpler terms?
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II. Key Concepts

1. Stimulus and Manifestation

Dispositions are typically understood in terms of:

- **Stimulus (S)**: the triggering condition
- **Manifestation (M)**: the resulting behavior

Examples:

Disposition	Stimulus (S)	Manifestation (M)
Fragility	Being struck	Breaking
Solubility	Being placed in water	Dissolving
Conductivity	Contact with electric current	Carrying current

2. Dispositional vs Non-Dispositional Properties

A traditional distinction:

- **Dispositional properties**
 - Defined by what something *would do*
 - e.g. fragility, flammability
 - **Non-dispositional (categorical) properties**
 - What something *is like in itself*
 - e.g. shape, mass, molecular structure
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3. Analysandum vs Analysans

When philosophers analyze a concept:

- **Analysandum** = the concept to be analyzed
- **Analysans** = the proposed analysis

Example:

- Analysandum: "x is fragile"
 - Analysans: "x would break if struck"
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III. The Classical View: The Conditional Analysis

The most influential theory:

Conditional Analysis:

x is disposed to give response M to stimulus S

iff if x were subjected to S, it would give M

Why This Is Attractive

- Simple and elegant
 - Reduces dispositions to **counterfactuals** (“what would happen if...”)
 - Fits everyday language
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Example

A glass is fragile iff it would break if struck

IV. Problems for the Conditional Analysis

Even before Lewis, philosophers noticed complications.

1. Masking

A disposition can be **present but prevented from manifesting**:

- A fragile glass wrapped in foam:
 - It is fragile
 - But it would not break if struck (because protected)

The conditional seems false, but the disposition is present.

2. Mimicking

Something can **behave like it has a disposition without actually having it**:

- A sturdy glass that shatters due to an external bomb:
 - It breaks when struck

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- But not because it is fragile

The conditional seems true, but the disposition is absent.

3. Finkishness (Preview of Lewis)

- A disposition that disappears when triggered
- Or appears only when triggered

These cases create systematic counterexamples.

V. Causal Basis Intuition

A widely held idea:

Dispositions are grounded in underlying **causal structures**

Example:

- Fragility is grounded in:
 - Molecular bonding
 - Internal stress structure

These are sometimes called:

- **Causal bases**
 - Or (traditionally) **categorical bases**
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VI. Competing Theories of Dispositions

1. Conditional Analysis (Reductionist)

- Dispositions = counterfactual conditionals
 - Problem: counterexamples (masking, finks)
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2. Causal Basis Theories

- Dispositions grounded in underlying properties
 - Often combined with counterfactuals
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3. Dispositional Essentialism (Anti-Reductionist)

- Dispositions are **irreducible**
 - Properties *just are* powers
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VII. Why This Matters

Dispositions connect to major philosophical issues:

- **Causation**: what makes things bring about effects?
 - **Laws of nature**: are laws grounded in powers?
 - **Modality**: how do we understand “would” and “could”?
 - **Scientific explanation**: are properties defined by behavior?
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Bottom Line

- Dispositions seem simple—but resist simple analysis
 - The conditional analysis captures something important—but not everything
 - Lewis’s paper is an attempt to **save what’s right** while fixing what’s wrong
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